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The Discovery of Ignorance

WERE, SAY, A SPANISH PEASANT TO HAVE fallen asleep in AD 1000 and woken up 500 years later, to the din of Columbus' sailors boarding the *Niña*, *Pinta* and *Santa Maria*, the world would have seemed to him quite familiar. Despite many changes in technology, manners and political boundaries, this medieval Rip Van Winkle would have felt at home. But had one of Columbus' sailors fallen into a similar slumber and woken up to the ringtone of a twenty-first-century iPhone, he would have found himself in a world strange beyond comprehension. 'Is this heaven?' he might well have asked himself. 'Or perhaps – hell?'

The last 500 years have witnessed a phenomenal and unprecedented growth in human power. In the year 1500, there were about 500 million *Homo sapiens* in the entire world. By 2024, *Sapiens* numbers exploded to more than 8 billion.[1] The total value of goods and services produced by humankind in the year 1500 is estimated at $500 billion, in today's dollars.[2] In the early 2020s the value of a year of human production is more than $100 trillion.[3] In 1500, humanity consumed the energy equivalent of half a million tons of oil every day. Now humanity consumes the equivalent of more than 43 million tons of oil per day.[4] (Take a second look at those figures – human population has increased 16-fold, production 200-fold, and energy consumption 86-fold.)

Suppose a single modern battleship got transported back to Columbus' time. In a matter of seconds it could make driftwood out of the *Niña*, *Pinta*